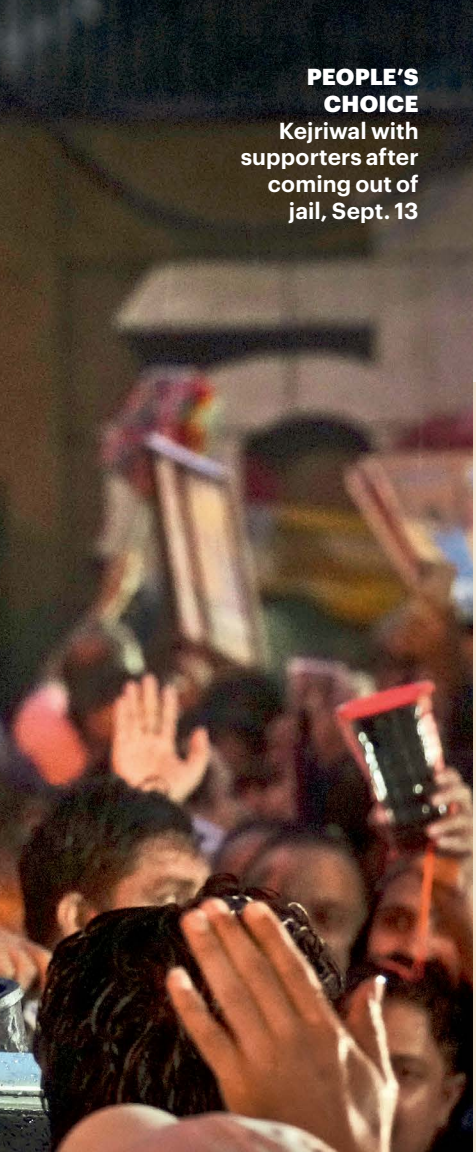


PEOPLE'S CHOICE Kejriwal with supporters after coming out of jail, Sept. 13

PTI

Kejri's Googly

- Kejriwal became India's first sitting CM to be jailed—in the disputed liquor policy case
- After getting regular bail in September, quit CM post, said he'll run for re-election with public support
- Skillfully handled internal party changes, bringing Atishi to the fore among more senior leaders
- Delhi's autonomy has been Kejriwal's cause celebre, resisting Centre's bid to take over UT's administrative services
- Has used his arrest and leadership record to form a strong story and elicit public sympathy

It may have been the toughest year of his life, jail for alleged corruption being antithetical to his very political raison d'être. But canny Kejriwal is eking electoral mileage out of it

went around constituencies with folded hands and sought "justice" for her husband. "They (the BJP-led Centre) have jailed him only because he has built schools and hospitals for Delhi," Sunita said at every public meeting.

It's hard to say what electoral impact the 'liquor scam' case can have now. AAP is on a much better wicket than, say, six months back. All their leaders, including Kejriwal's No. 2 Manish Sisodia, have got bail, and as the AAP chief never tires of repeating, "not one paisa [of illegally acquired monies] has been found" after two years of investigation by the central agencies.

After 50 days of incarceration, Kejriwal finally secured interim bail to campaign in the Lok Sabha election. And he used it to the hilt. The very next day he set the proverbial cat among the pigeons in the BJP camp. "Prime Minister Narendra Modiji will be 75 next year," he said at a press meet. "As per their own rule, one can't hold official posts after turning 75. So Modiji will retire and Amit Shah will become PM." It's not clear if the voters took it seriously—the AAP-Congress combine lost all seven seats in Delhi—but it certainly set the saffron camp aflutter for the next few days. Shah, party chief J.P. Nadda and other party biggies were left clarifying to the media that there was no question of Modi retiring. Kejriwal had put an unspoken, uncomfortable and unresolved point internal to the BJP out for public consumption.

He has been finding it hard keeping his own house in order. In May, longtime comrade and Rajya Sabha MP Swati Maliwal stormed out of the party after alleging assault by his aide Bibhav Kumar inside the CM's residence. The party has also been losing leaders to the BJP, the latest being former Delhi minister Kailash Gahlot, a domino effect of Kejriwal installing trusted lieutenant Atishi as caretaker CM.

Right now, what's imperative for AAP is retaining power in Delhi in the 2025 election. Kejriwal has already sounded the battle cry ahead of others with outreach initiatives in Delhi's semi-unauthorised neighbourhoods and slums where AAP has traditionally held an edge. These days he is busy spelling out the freebies the party intends to shower on people if it returns to power: a doubling of the mint-fresh Rs 1,000 monthly dole to women, free treatment for senior citizens, Rs 10 lakh life insurance and Rs 5 lakh accident insurance for auto-drivers, the list goes on.

In response, the state BJP has been raising issues like the crores in public funds spent buffing up the CM's residence, the liquor 'case' and so on. But, then again, perhaps they are just giving him what he wants: keeping the conversation focused around him. And for better or for worse, that's exactly what Kejriwal got in 2024. ■